Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

2 John

2 John 1:1

- The elder: The apostle John calls himself "the elder" to affirm his authority in the church.
- To the chosen lady and her children: The Greek word kuria could be the name of a specific woman. However, it more likely refers to a local church and its members (see 1:13).
- whom I love in the truth: This could mean "truly love" (see 1:5–6). More likely, it refers to the love shared by people who confess the same truth about Christ. This truth stands in contrast to the lies taught by the false teachers (1:7; see 1 John 2:21–23). John stresses the pronoun I to emphasize the difference from the false teachers, who lack love and reject the true church.

2 John 1:1–3

- The apostle John begins a common introduction for a personal letter.
- He mentions truth four times in this short opening and once more in 1:4. John wanted his readers to know the truths about Jesus Christ, to live according to those truths, and not to be led away by false teachers.

2 John 1:2

Christian love comes from understanding the truth. The truth that lives in us is more than just facts or teachings. The truth is the presence of God, who will be with us forever (see John 14:15–17).

2 John 1:3

Grace, mercy, and peace are blessings that John is confident God will give. These blessings are for people who live in truth and love and who show by their actions that they belong to God.

2 John 1:4–11

John now applies the truth and love that he mentioned in the introduction (1:1–3) to the situation of those he is writing to. Living in truth and love means maintaining unity or fellowship with true Christians (1:4–6). It also involves recognizing false teachers and choosing not to listen to or support them (1:7–11).

2 John 1:5

I urge you, dear lady: See study note on 1:1.

2 John 1:7

- Many deceivers have gone out into the world: These people included the Docetists, who denied that Jesus Christ came in a real human body. John argued strongly against this false teaching in his first letter (see 1 John 4:2–3).
- A false teacher is a deceiver because they mislead believers who are not careful. Such a person is also an antichrist because they turn people away from the true Christ. By using this strong apocalyptic title, antichrist, John shows how serious this false teaching is and points to the judgment that false teachers will face.

2 John 1:8

we: This word refers to the apostles and their co-workers. The apostles taught the truth and defended it against false teachings. Believers, referred to as you, are warned to guard their faith against teachings that could lead them away from God (1:9).

2 John 1:9

Anyone who runs ahead without remaining in the teaching: To run ahead means to disagree with the apostles' teachings about Jesus Christ and believe things the apostles did not teach. This is a warning to the church not to listen to the false teachers.

2 John 1:10–11

Christians should not invite any person who does not teach the truth about Christ into their homes. In the early church, Christians met for worship in homes (see Acts 2:46; 5:42; 8:3; 12:5, 12; Colossians 4:15; Philemon 1:2). Because of this, John may be referring to inviting false teachers into a meeting of the church.

This instruction may also refer to giving any type of hospitality to false teachers. Showing hospitality would support their work and help their message spread. John teaches that the only way to respond to them is to refuse to welcome them into the fellowship.

2 John 1:12

- The English expression "face to face" has the same meaning as the Greek expression used here, which is literally "mouth to mouth" (see also 3 John 1:14).
- so that our joy may be complete: This means that our relationship with Christ is not only a private experience. We experience the greatest joy when we live in peaceful fellowship with other believers.

2 John 1:13

2 John 1:13

The children of your elect sister: This probably refers to the sister church in Ephesus and its members. John was staying with them (see 1:1). He lived in that region and cared for several churches.